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EDUCATION



Shanghai University of International Business and Economics Fall 2024 - Present
School of Global Governance M.Phil. Candidate in Law and Economics



Qilu University of Technology (Shandong Academy of Sciences) Fall 2019 - Summer 2023
School of Politics and Law LL.B.



Qilu University of Technology (Shandong Academy of Sciences) Fall 2019 - Summer 2023
Department of Economics and Management B.Sc. in Economics

HONORS & AWARDS

• **2024 Fall Semester**

- **Second Prize of Excellent Papers**, *2024 Annual Conference of International Economic Law of Zhejiang Law Society.*
- **Award of Excellent Papers**, *2024 Annual Conference of the Law and Economics Research Society of Hubei Law Society.*
- **Award of Excellence Team**, the 14th *China WTO Moot Court Competition.*

• **2025 Spring Semester**

- **Third Prize of Excellent Papers**, *Workshop on Reform and Innovation of the WTO.*

• **2025 Fall Semester**

- **First Prize of Excellent Papers** and **Second Prize of Excellent Papers**, *2025 Annual Conference of International Economic Law of Zhejiang Law Society.*
- **First-Class Academic Scholarship**, Shanghai University of International Business and Economics.

• **2026 Spring Semester**

- **Third Prize of Excellent Papers**, “Fayan Lighthouse” National Judicial Big Data Essay Contest.

WORKING PAPERS

1. **Wu Zi-Jie**, Judicial Decisions Under Pressure: Evidence from the Chinese Judiciary (Working Paper, [Link](#)).

Abstract: *This paper studies whether caseload pressure changes appellate decision-making. Using 3.3 million Chinese civil appellate decisions from 2013 to 2021, I link appellate outcomes to judge-level workload and written reasoning. I instrument a presiding judge’s caseload with the leave-one-out workload of other presiding judges in the same court and month. A doubling of appellate caseload increases the probability that the appellate court upholds the first-instance judgment by about 0.7 percentage points. Heavier caseloads also reduce legal citations and increase textual similarity between first- and second-instance reasoning. The results show that court congestion changes not only how quickly courts process disputes, but also how intensively appellate judges review lower-court decisions.*

2. **Wu Zi-Jie**, When the Sun Goes Down: Darkness, Crime, and the Substitutability of Public Infrastructure and Services (Working Paper; Chinese version won the Third Prize in the Graduate Student Group of the 2025 “Fayan Lighthouse” National Judicial Big Data Essay Contest; English version is still at an early preliminary stage, [English Version Link](#))

Abstract: *With a novel hour-level criminal records dataset, this article provides the first empirical evidence on how sunlight affects criminal activity in China. Exploiting the exogenous variation in sunset time during a day as a natural experiment, we find that darkness significantly increases criminal activity by approximately 4.5%. Moreover, this effect is entirely driven by robbery and theft, with no significant impact on other impulsive violent offenses. Finally, we document that public infrastructure and service act as an effective substitute for natural light: the criminogenic effect of darkness is significantly attenuated in cities with higher density of more nightlights, more frontline police force, while the road density exaggerated the effect of darkness. Our findings highlight the role of visibility and policing as a binding constraint on criminal behavior and underscore the social value of public safety investments.*

3. **Wu Zi-Jie**, Judicial Reform and Breakthrough Innovation: Evidence from China, *Economic Change and Restructuring* (Under Review, [Link](#))

Abstract: *China’s 2020 complex-simple civil case diversion reform increased breakthrough patents by 24.9 percent, while leaving total and incremental patents statistically unchanged. The paper uses the reform as a quasi-natural experiment that improved the speed of civil dispute resolution in 20 pilot cities. The evidence points to a financial-enforcement channel: treated courts resolve debt-related civil cases faster, exposed firms receive more trade credit, face lower financing constraints, and raise R&D spending. The effect is larger in technologically specialized city-industry cells and in industries with higher litigation intensity. The results show that procedural judicial efficiency matters for innovation because firms need enforceable contracts to finance and organize risky research.*

4. Gang Chen, **Zi-Jie Wu** (Second Author), Chao Lei, Siyu Wang, Zhiting Wu, Central-Local Industrial Policy Coordination, Local Comparative Advantage, and High-Quality Innovation (*The Journal of World Economy* (世界经济), Under Review)

Abstract: *Against the background of the central government’s continued strengthening of industrial guidance and local governments’ active implementation of national strategies, how central-local industrial policy coordination affects local innovation is an important question for understanding high-quality development and the construction of a modern industrial system. Based on the texts of central and local government work reports, this paper constructs measures of central and local policy preferences at the industry level and their similarity, and combines these measures with city-industry-level innovation data to examine the effects and mechanisms of local governments’ following of central industrial priorities on different types of innovation. The paper finds that, overall, greater alignment between local industrial policy and central guidance is associated with stronger innovation performance, but this positive relationship exhibits significant industrial heterogeneity. In non-advantage industries, local following of central guidance significantly suppresses breakthrough innovation; in advantage industries, such following produces a stronger promoting effect on breakthrough innovation. Mechanism analyses show that, in non-advantage industries, local following suppresses breakthrough innovation by aggravating resource misallocation, whereas in advantage industries it promotes breakthrough innovation by increasing R&D intensity. The paper shows that central-local industrial policy coordination is not a simple matter of “the more consistent, the better”; its economic consequences depend heavily on whether central guidance matches local comparative advantage. Only when comparative advantage is respected and local conditions are taken into account can central guidance be transformed into sustained momentum for high-quality innovation and effective investment.*

- (a) My main contribution: Following the text-analysis method proposed by Kelly et al. (2021, *AER: Insights*), I used Chinese patent application data from 2005 to 2025 to calculate each patent’s forward and backward similarity, evaluate its breakthrough level, and construct city-level breakthrough innovation measures as the core dependent variables of the paper.

5. Gang Chen, **Zi-Jie Wu** (Second Author), Chong Wang, Urban Spatial Aesthetics, Innovation Factor Allocation, and Breakthrough Innovation (*China Economic Quarterly* (经济学 (季刊)) , Under Review)

Abstract: *This paper examines the effect of urban street aesthetics on the share of breakthrough innovation. Street aesthetics are measured using Baidu historical street-view images and MIT's Place Pulse street-view evaluation algorithm, which identifies aesthetic scores through pairwise comparisons. To address endogeneity, the paper further maps modern and contemporary calligraphy and painting art to cities' historical aesthetic endowments and interacts these measures with the textual intensity of urban renewal and landscape governance to construct an instrumental variable. The paper finds that urban street aesthetics significantly increase the share of breakthrough innovation, and this conclusion remains robust after replacing the measure and using instrumental-variable estimation. The effect is concentrated in technology-intensive industries and operates through the agglomeration of high-end talent and the enhancement of autonomous knowledge absorption.*

- (a) My main contribution: Following Huang et al. (2019, *Journal of Financial Research* (金融研究)), I used web scraping to collect approximately five million art auction records in China from 1995 to 2024 and constructed the instrumental variable used in this paper based on these data.

EXTRACURRICULAR ACTIVITIES



Roma Tre University & Beijing Normal University
Fundamentals of European Private Law

March 2025

13th China WTO Moot Court Competition
Researcher

September - November 2024

INTERNSHIP

Research Assistant, SUIBE, Shanghai

September 2024 - June 2025

People's Court of Licheng District, Quanzhou

July - August 2022

People's Procuratorate of Quanzhou

July - August 2021

SKILLS

- **Data Processing:** Collected, cleaned, and processed a China Judgments Online criminal case text dataset containing approximately 4 million criminal case records from 2013 to 2021, and collapsed it into a county-level panel dataset using **Python and Stata**. Part of the *source code is available at: [Link](#)*
 - Used **regular expressions** to identify keywords from full-text judgments and extract crime-type features.
 - Used the **geopandas** package in Python to identify corresponding counties based on **latitude and longitude** fields.
- **Basic Programming:** Able to use AI agents to assist with Python and Stata tasks, including data cleaning and variable construction.